

HABITATS

The habitats of the Alps are found elsewhere in the world, but here their characteristics are contrasted by large differences in altitude. The grasses and herbs found in a high alpine meadow, for example, are very different from those in a lowland grassland.

MOUNTAINS AND SCREE SLOPES

Mountains are effectively inland islands, where unique species can live and evolve in isolation. Slope habitats are heavily influenced by latitude, altitude, incline, aspect, and the underlying rock. Conditions above the tree line (beyond which no trees grow) are harsh.

MONTANE FOREST

Forests on mountains are banded according to altitude, with broadleaf trees dominating the warmer, lower slopes, and conifers thriving on higher ground up to the tree line. Because sloping, rocky ground is difficult to farm, mountainsides often retain more tree cover than flatter ground.

ALPINE MEADOW

Where flooding or unstable ground prevent trees encroaching, grasses and herbs flourish in spectacular diversity. At high-altitude, there is a sudden burst of growth in spring and summer and the meadows are filled with blooms—an important food source for many animals.

FOOD CHAINS

One way all the plants and animals in a habitat interact is via a food chain. Plants convert the Sun's energy into food for growth and reproduction, and are eaten by herbivorous animals. These in turn become food for predatory or scavenging animals.



EAGLE OWL

The Eurasian eagle owl is the top predatory bird in the Alps. It hunts mainly small mammals, but will also target other birds of prey.



MARMOT

Alpine marmots spend the summer months feeding on lush grasses and herbs, building up fat to help them survive the long alpine winter.



DANDELION

As well as providing food for marmots, alpine dandelions are a welcome source of nectar for butterflies and bees.